MIL-T-44208
15 January 1986

MILITARY SPECIFICATION

TUNA WITH NOODLES, THERMOSTABILIZED, FOR MEAL, READY-TO-EAT

This specification is approved for use by all Departments and Agencies of the Department of Defense.

1. SCOPE

1.1 Scope. This document covers thermostabilized tuna with noodles in flexible pouches for use as a component of the Meal, Ready-to-Eat, Individual and Meal, Flight Feeding, Individual.

2. APPLICABLE DOCUMENTS

2.1 Government documents. Unless otherwise specified, the following documents of the issue in effect on date of invitation for bids or request for proposal form a part of this document to the extent specified herein.

SPECIFICATIONS

MILITARY

MIL-P-44073 - Packaging and Thermoprocessing of Foods in Flexible Pouches

STANDARDS

MILITARY

MIL-STD-105 - Sampling Procedures and Tables for Inspection by Attributes

Beneficial comments (recommendations, additions, deletions) and any pertinent data which may be of use in improving this document should be addressed to: U.S. Army Natick Research, Development and Engineering Center, Natick, MA 01760-5014 by using the self-addressed Standardization Document Improvement Proposal (DD Form 1426) appearing at the end of this document or by letter.

AMSC N/A

FSC 8940

DISTRIBUTION STATEMENT A. Approved for public release; distribution is unlimited.

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MIL-STD-900 - Bacterial Standards for Starches, Flours, Cereals, Alimentary Pastes, Dry Milks, and Sugars Used in Preparation of Thermostabilized Foods for the Armed Forces.

(Copies of documents required by contractors in connection with specific acquisition functions should be obtained from the contracting activity or as directed by the contracting activity.)

OTHER GOVERNMENT DOCUMENTS

U.S. DEPARTMENT OF HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES

Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act and Regulations Promulgated Thereunder (21 CFR Parts 1-199) includes:

U.S. Standard of Identity for Cream Cheese
U.S. Standard of Identity for Canned Tuna
U.S. Standard of Identity for Enriched Egg Noodles

(Applications for copies should be addressed to the Superintendent of Documents, U.S. Government Printing Office, Washington, D.C. 20402.)

U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE (USDA)

U.S. Standards for Grades of Canned Mushrooms
U.S. Standards for Grades of Frozen Peas

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Chief, Processed Products Branch, Fruit and Vegetable Division, Agricultural Marketing Service, U.S. Department of Agriculture, Washington, D.C. 20250.)

U.S. DEPARTMENT OF COMMERCE (USDC)

Regulations Governing Processed Fishery Products (50 CFR Part 260)

(Application for copies should be addressed to the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, National Marine Fisheries Service, National Seafood Inspection Program, 3000 Whitehaven Street, N.W., Washington, D.C. 20235.)

ENVIRONMENTAL PROTECTION AGENCY (EPA)

National Interim Primary Drinking Water Regulations

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Office of Drinking Water WH 550, Environmental Protection Agency, Washington, D.C. 20460.)

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2.2 Other publications. Unless otherwise specified, the following documents of the issue in effect on date of invitation for bids or request for proposal, form a part of this document to the extent specified herein.

ASSOCIATION OF OFFICIAL ANALYTICAL CHEMISTS (AOAC)

Official Methods of Analysis of the Association of Official Analytical Chemists

(Application for copies should be addressed to the Association of Official Analytical Chemists, 1111 North 19th Street, Suite 210, Arlington, VA 22209.)

NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES

Food Chemicals Codex

(Application for copies should be addressed to the National Academy Press, 2101 Constitution Avenue, N.W., Washington, D.C. 20418.)

(Technical society and technical association documents are generally available for reference from libraries. They are also distributed among technical groups and using Federal agencies.)

2.3 Order of precedence. In the event of a conflict between the text of this document and the references cited herein, the text of this document shall take precedence.

3. REQUIREMENTS

3.1 First article. When specified in the contract or purchase order, a sample shall be subjected to first article inspection (see 4.4, 6.1, and 6.2).

3.2 Ingredients. All ingredients shall be clean, sound, wholesome, and free from foreign material, evidence of rodent or insect infestation, extraneous material, off-odors, off-flavors, and off-colors.

3.2.1 Tuna, canned. Canned tuna shall be chunk style, light tuna packed in water. The canned tuna shall comply with the U.S. Standard of Identity for Canned Tuna.

3.2.2 Noodles, egg, (fettuccini), enriched. The egg noodles shall meet the U.S. Standard of Identity for Enriched Egg Noodles. The egg noodles shall be dried with no checking or cracking. The egg noodles shall have the following dimensions:

Length:	4.0 inches $\pm$ 0.5 (1/2) inch
Width:	0.25 (1/4) inch $\pm$ 0.0625 (1/16) inch
Thickness:	0.043 inch $\pm$ 0.003 inch

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The egg noodles shall conform to the following analytical requirements when tested in accordance with the Official Methods of Analysis of the Association of Official Analytical Chemists:

Moisture:	Not greater than 12.00 percent
Ash:	Not greater than 0.98 percent (moisture-free basis)
Protein:	Not less than 13.00 percent (moisture-free basis)
Egg solids:	Not less than 5.50 percent by weight
Lipid phosphorus:	Not less than 0.136 percent if product is prepared with egg yolk solids; not less than 0.101 percent if product is prepared with whole eggs.

The egg noodles shall comply with bacterial standards specified in MIL-STD-900.

3.2.3 Water. Water used for formulation, blanching, ice-making, and washing shall conform to the National Interim Primary Drinking Water Regulations.

3.2.4 Cheese, cream, fresh. The fresh cream cheese shall comply with the U.S. Standard of Identity for Cream Cheese. The cream cheese shall have a mild, aromatic flavor and odor suggestive of lactic cultures, and shall be moderately salted. The cream cheese shall have a comparatively light texture, reasonably firm body, no free whey, and be uniformly creamy-white in color. The cream cheese may have a very slight, clean acid taste and odor or slight cooked flavor, but shall be free from bitter, sour, flat, yeasty, or moldy flavors. The body and texture shall not be coarse, crumbly, excessively smooth, gummy, grainy, sticky, overfirm, or too soft. The cream cheese shall be in excellent condition, free of mold, slime, discoloration, or burnt particles.

3.2.5 Shortening, vegetable, powdered. The powdered vegetable shortening shall consist of components which, when combined, will serve as a product whitening agent. The powdered shortening, when used as an ingredient in this product, shall withstand the conditions of thermoprocessing specified in this document without browning. A typical analysis of this powdered shortening follows:

Fat	75.00 percent ± 1.50 percent
Protein	5.50 percent ± 0.50 percent
Carbohydrates	15.00 percent ± 1.00 percent
Moisture	2.00 percent maximum

3.2.6 Mushrooms, canned, stems and pieces. The canned mushrooms (stems and pieces style) shall be U.S. Grade B or better of the U.S. Standards for Grades of Canned Mushrooms.

3.2.7 Peas

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3.2.7.1 Peas, green, fresh. The peas shall be fresh, sweet green peas of a variety suitable for canning. The shelled peas shall be well-formed, bright, young, tender, and of such size as to not pass through a 9/32-inch sieve.

3.2.7.2 Peas, green, frozen. Frozen peas shall comply with the U.S. Grade A requirements of the U.S. Standards for Grades of Frozen Peas and shall be of the latest season's crop.

3.2.8 Salt. Salt shall be non-iodized, free-flowing, white, refined sodium chloride with or without anti-caking agents.

3.2.9 Celery, sliced, dehydrated. The dehydrated celery slices shall be obtained from clean, sound Pascal type celery. The slices shall be approximately 3/8-inch cross-cut stalk slices with no leaf cuts. The slices shall be free flowing with a uniform bright color. The dehydrated celery shall have a moisture content not in excess of 4.5 percent and a sulphur dioxide content of 750 $\pm$ 250 ppm.

3.2.10 Pepper, white, ground. Ground white pepper shall be derived from the dried mature berries of Piper nigrum L. from which the outer covering or the outer and inner coverings have been removed. The ground white pepper shall have a characteristic penetrating odor, a hot biting pungent flavor, and a light color. The ground white pepper shall contain not less than 1.0 mL of volatile oil per 100 grams of ground white pepper and shall be of such size that not less than 95 percent shall pass through a U.S. Standard No. 40 sieve.

3.2.11 Bay leaves, ground. Ground bay leaves shall be derived from the dried leaves of Laurus nobilis L. The bay leaves shall possess a pleasant aromatic odor and pungent, mildly bitter flavor with a pale green to yellow green color. A minimum of 95 percent shall pass through a U.S. Standard No. 30 sieve. Volatile oil content shall be not less than 1.0 mL of volatile oil per 100 grams of ground bay leaves.

3.2.12 Oil, vegetable. The vegetable oil shall have a stability of at least 15 hours (Active Oxygen Method), a free fatty acid content not to exceed 0.05 percent by weight, and a moisture/volatile matter content not to exceed 0.06 percent by weight and shall pass the cold test of 5.5 hours (minimum).

3.2.13 Starch, modified, high opacity. The high opacity starch shall be white, odorless, finely pulverized modified maize food starch for use in canned foods and shall comply with MIL-STD-900. The modified starch shall demonstrate initial viscosity development in the temperature range of 140° to 170°F and a typical viscosity (be fully hydrated) at common retort temperatures. It shall resist breakdown at low pH, under shear stress, and under conditions of cold storage. The cooked modified starch slurry shall be bland with essentially no cereal or starch taste.

3.2.14 Lecithin. Lecithin shall comply with the Food Chemicals Codex.

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3.2.15 Color, annatto, dry. The annatto color shall be a reddish orange water soluble powder of the extractive of Annatto bixa orellana. The powder shall contain less than 5.0 percent moisture and shall be free from hard lumps. One hundred percent of the powder shall pass through a U.S. No. 10 sieve. The total color (as percent Norbixin) shall be 15 percent.

3.2.16 Preblended spice and seasoning mixture. Preblended spices and seasonings may be used. The spices and seasonings in the mixture shall comply with the requirements of this document. The containers used for the spice and seasoning blend shall be labeled with each ingredient in the blend. The ingredients shall be in the same proportions as specified in the ingredient formula.

3.3 Preparation and further processing. Preparation and further processing shall be on a continuous basis.

3.3.1 Tuna preparation. The canned tuna shall be drained. The water pack liquid shall not be included in the end product. The drained tuna shall be mixed so as to yield distinct tuna particles in the end product. The mixed tuna shall be held for not more than 4 hours in the temperature range of 28° to 40°F until filled into the pouches.

3.3.2 Mushroom preparation. The canned mushrooms shall be thoroughly drained and the drained brine shall be retained for inclusion in the sauce (see 3.3.4). Drained mushrooms shall be incorporated into the sauce within 2 hours after draining.

3.3.3 Noodle preparation. The noodles shall be prepared as follows:

a. The dry noodles shall be batch weighed.

b. The weighed noodles shall be blanched for 3 minutes in boiling water, stirring constantly.

c. After blanching, the noodles shall be rinsed in cold water to a temperature less than 90°F.

d. The blanched noodles shall be reweighed.

e. If the weight of the blanched noodles is not at least double the dry weight of the noodles, the difference in weight shall be added as extra water to the sauce after adjustment of the cooked sauce volume for evaporation losses before filling.

f. The noodles shall be filled into pouches within 2 hours after the completion of blanching.

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3.3.4 Sauce formulation and preparation. The sauce shall be formulated and prepared as follows:

Ingredients	Percent by weight
Water and mushroom brine	77.628
Cream cheese	4.500
Powdered vegetable shortening	2.000
Mushrooms, stems and pieces, drained	6.000
Green peas, fresh or frozen	3.500
Salt 1/	0.750
Celery, sliced, dehydrated	0.250
Pepper, white, ground	0.100
Bay leaves, ground	0.020
Vegetable oil	3.000
Starch, modified, high opacity	2.000
Lecithin	0.250
Annatto powder	0.002

1/ The total amount of salt in the sauce formula shall be adjusted as necessary to produce a product that complies with the finished product salt requirements (see 3.6).

a. A slurry shall be made using the starch, powdered vegetable shortening, and part of the water and mushroom brine.

b. An emulsion shall be made by mixing the remaining ingredients in a steam jacketed kettle. The emulsion shall be heated to 180° to 190°F.

c. The slurry shall be added to the emulsion with vigorous mixing.

d. The mixture shall be stirred continuously while being heated to 180° to 190°F.

e. The volume of the final mixture shall be adjusted with water to compensate for evaporation loss during heating and holding.

f. The sauce shall be filled into pouches within 4 hours after cooking. If a hot fill method is used, the prepared sauce shall be held at 150° to 180°F at all times prior to filling into the pouches. If a cold fill method is used, the prepared sauce shall be cooled immediately and held in the temperature range of 28° to 40°F at all times prior to filling into the pouches.

3.3.5 Product preparation. The tuna, noodles, and sauce shall be combined in pouches in the following proportions, using either a single or multi-stage filling operation.

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Ingredient	Percent by weight
Tuna, drained	25.0
Noodles, blanched	25.0
Sauce	50.0

3.4 Pouch filling and sealing. Each pouch (see 5.1) shall be filled with product such as to conform to the finished product requirements and to the following requirements:

a. Each pouch shall be filled and sealed in accordance with the pouch filling and sealing requirements specified for class 1 of MIL-P-44073.

b. Each filled and sealed pouch shall be in the retort process within 1 hour after sealing.

3.5 Pouch thermoprocessing. The filled and sealed pouches shall be thermostabilized by retorting until a sterilization value (Fo) of not less than 6 has been achieved. The thermoprocessing operation shall be in compliance with the thermoprocessing requirements for class 1 of MIL-P-44073.

3.6 Finished product requirements. The finished product shall comply with the following requirements:

a. There shall be no foreign material such as, but not limited to, dirt, insect parts, hair, wood, paper, paint, glass, or metal.

b. There shall be no foreign odor or flavor such as, but not limited to, burnt, scorched, stale, sour, rancid, musty or moldy.

c. There shall be no color foreign to the product.

d. The average net weight shall be not less than 8.0 ounces.

e. No individual pouch shall contain less than 7.5 ounces of product.

f. The average drained weight of tuna shall be not less than 2.0 ounces.

g. No individual pouch shall contain less than 1.5 ounces of drained tuna.

h. The average drained weight of noodles and vegetables shall be not less than 3.5 ounces.

i. No individual pouch shall contain less than 3.0 ounces of drained noodles and vegetables.

j. The product shall have the appearance of a uniform distribution of tuna, noodles, and vegetables.

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k. Texture of the tuna shall not be dry, rubbery, or mushy.

l. Texture of the noodles shall not be mushy or tough.

m. Texture of the mushrooms shall not be mushy or tough.

n. Sauce consistency shall be smooth, without lumps, and shall not be excessively thick or thin.

o. The average fat content shall be not greater than 3.0 percent.

p. The fat content of the product in any individual pouch shall be not greater than 5.0 percent.

q. The salt content of the product in any individual pouch shall be not greater than 1.2 percent nor less than 0.5 percent.

r. The product shall show no evidence of excessive heating (materially darkened or scorched).

3.6.1 Palatability. The product shall be equal to or better than the approved preproduction sample (see 6.1) in palatability and overall appearance.

3.7 Plant qualification. The tuna component shall originate and be produced, processed, and stored in U.S. Department of Commerce Official Establishments operating under contract inspection with the U.S. Department of Commmerce in accordance with the Regulations Governing Processed Fishery Products. The dairy component shall originate from a dairy plant which is approved by the Dairy Grading Section, Dairy Division, Agricultural Marketing Service, U.S. Department of Agriculture. Other components and the finished product shall originate and be produced, processed, and stored in plants regularly operating under U.S. Department of Agriculture applicable inspection regulations.

3.8 Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act. All deliveries shall conform in every respect to the provisions of the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act, and Regulations Promulgated Thereunder.

4. QUALITY ASSURANCE PROVISIONS

4.1 Contractor's responsibility. Inspection and acceptance by the USDA shall not relieve the contractor of obligation and responsibility to deliver a product complying with all requirements of this document. The contractor shall assure product compliance prior to submitting the product to the USDA for any inspection.

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4.2 Inspection and certification. Product acceptability shall be determined by the USDA. The USDA will determine the degree of supervision necessary to assure compliance with the requirements of this document.

4.3 Classification of inspection. The inspection requirements specified herein are classified as follows:

a. First article inspection (see 4.4).
b. Quality conformance inspection (see 4.5).

4.4 First article inspection. When a first article is required (see 6.1), it shall be inspected in accordance with the quality assurance provisions of this document and evaluated for overall appearance and palatability. Any failure to conform to the quality assurance provisions of this document or any appearance or palatability failure shall be cause for rejection of the first article.

4.5 Quality conformance inspection. Unless otherwise specified, sampling for inspection shall be performed in accordance with MIL-STD-105.

4.5.1 Component and material inspection. In accordance with 4.1, components and materials shall be inspected in accordance with all the requirements of referenced documents unless otherwise excluded, amended, modified, or qualified in this document or other applicable purchase document.

4.5.1.1 Ingredient and component examination. Conformance of ingredients and components to identity, condition, and other requirements specified in 3.2 shall be certified by the ingredient supplier or ingredient manufacturer, or compliance be evident by examination of pertinent labels, markings, U.S. Grade certificates, certificates of analyses, or other such valid documents acceptable to the inspection agency. In addition, prior to use, each ingredient shall be examined organoleptically, as necessary, to determine conformance to the condition requirements. Any nonconformance to an identity, condition, or other requirement shall be cause for rejection of the ingredient or component lot or of any involved product.

4.5.2 In-process examination. In-process examination shall be performed to determine conformance to the preparation, processing, filling, sealing, and packaging requirements. Any nonconformance revealed by actual examination or by review of records of time, temperature, and formulation or of other valid documents shall be cause for rejection of the involved product.

4.5.3 Filled and sealed pouch inspection. Inspection of filled and sealed pouches shall be in accordance with the quality assurance provisions of MIL-P-44073.

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4.5.4 Net weight inspection. The net weight of the filled and sealed pouches shall be determined by weighing each sample unit on a suitable scale tared with a representative empty pouch. Any individual net weight of less than 7.5 ounces shall be scored as a minor defect. The lot size shall be expressed in pouches. The sample unit shall be one filled and sealed pouch. The inspection level shall be S-3 and the acceptable quality level (AQL), expressed in terms of defects per hundred units, shall be 2.5. Results shall be reported to the nearest 0.1 ounce. In addition, the lot shall be rejected if the sample average net weight is less than 8.0 ounces.

4.5.5 Product inspection. The filled and sealed sample pouches shall be held for a minimum of 72 hours at room temperature (65° to 75°F) after completion of the thermoprocessing operation. The pouches shall be heated in boiling water for 10 minutes, opened, and inspected for the defects indicated in table I. The lot size shall be expressed in pouches. The sample unit shall be the contents of one pouch. The inspection level shall be S-3 and the AQL, expressed in terms of defects per hundred units, shall be 1.5.

TABLE I. Product defects 1/ 2/

Category	Defect
Major	
101	Drained weight of tuna in a pouch is less than 1.5 ounces. 3/ 4/
102	Drained weight of noodles and vegetables in a pouch is less than 3.0 ounces. 3/ 4/
103	Tuna, noodles, and vegetables not uniformly distributed.
104	Texture of tuna is dry, rubbery, or mushy. 5/
105	Texture of noodles is mushy or tough. 5/
106	Texture of mushrooms is mushy or tough. 5/
107	Sauce consistency is lumpy or excessively thick or thin.
108	Product shows evidence of excessive heating (materially darkened or scorched).

1/ The presence of foreign material (e.g., glass, dirt, insect parts, hair, wood, metal), foreign odor or flavor (e.g., burnt, scorched, moldy, rancid, sour, stale), or foreign color shall be cause for rejection of the lot.

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2/ Product not equal to or better than the approved preproduction sample (see 6.1) in palatability and overall appearance shall be cause for rejection of the lot. This comparison shall be made only when deemed necessary by an Agricultural Marketing Service (AMS) agent.

3/ To determine drained weight, the pouch contents shall be emptied into a flat bottom container. Approximately three times the pouch volume of 180° to 212°F water shall be added to the container so as to cover the contents. The contents and water shall be gently agitated so as to remove the sauce without breaking the noodles. The contents shall then be poured into a U.S. Standard No. 7 (0.111 inch) sieve in a manner that will distribute the product over the sieve without breaking the noodles. Sieve area shall be such that the distributed product does not completely cover all of the openings of the sieve. The sieve shall be tilted at an approximate 45° angle and allowed to drain for 2 minutes before determining the drained weight by subtracting the sieve tare weight from the gross weight. The drained weight of the tuna and the noodles and vegetables shall be determined individually and shall be reported to the nearest 0.1 ounce.

4/ The lot shall be rejected if the sample average drained weight of tuna is less than 2.0 ounces or if the sample average drained weight of noodles and vegetables is less than 3.5 ounces.

5/ Examination for appearance and texture conformance of the tuna, noodles, and mushrooms shall be made of representative pieces immediately following the determination of drained weight.

4.5.6 Fat and salt content testing. The unopened sample pouches shall be warmed in a water bath to melt fat adhering to the inside of the pouches. The sample pouches shall be opened and the entire contents of each pouch shall be separately blended in a Waring blender or equivalent. The fat and salt content of the product from each pouch in the sample shall be determined in accordance with the Official Methods of Analysis of the Association of Official Analytical Chemists, Chapter: Meat and Meat Products. Test results shall be reported to the nearest 0.1 percent. Any result failing to conform to the fat or salt requirement in 3.6 shall be classified as a major defect. The lot size shall be expressed in pouches. The sample unit shall be one filled and sealed pouch. The inspection level shall be S-2 and the AQL, expressed in terms of defects per hundred units, shall be 1.5.

4.5.7 Packaging inspection. Inspection of packaging shall be in accordance with the quality assurance provisions of MIL-P-44073.

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5. PACKAGING

5.1 Packaging. Packaging shall be in accordance with the requirements of MIL-P-44073.

6. NOTES

6.1 Ordering data. Acquisition documents should specify the following:

a. Title, number, and date of this document.
b. When a first article is required (see 3.1, 4.4 and 6.2).
c. Provisions for approved preproduction samples (see 3.6.1 and 6.2).

6.2 First article. When a first article is required, it shall be inspected and approved under the appropriate provisions of FAR 52.209. The first article should be a preproduction sample. The contracting officer should include specific instructions in all acquisition documents regarding arrangements for selection, inspection, and approval of the first article.

Custodians:

Army - GL
Navy - SA
Air Force - 50

Preparing activity:

Army - GL

Project No. 8940-0515

Review activities:

Army - MD, TS
Navy - MC, MS
DP - SS

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STANDARDIZATION DOCUMENT IMPROVEMENT PROPOSAL

(See Instructions – Reverse Side)

1. DOCUMENT NUMBER	2. DOCUMENT TITLE
MIL-T-44208	Tuna with Noodles, Thermostabilized, For Meal, Ready-to-Eat

3a. NAME OF SUBMITTING ORGANIZATION	4. TYPE OF ORGANIZATION (Mark one)
	☐ VENDOR
b. ADDRESS (Street, City, State, ZIP Code)	☐ USER
	☐ MANUFACTURER
	☐ OTHER (Specify): _____

5. PROBLEM AREAS

a. Paragraph Number and Wording:

b. Recommended Wording:

c. Reason/Rationale for Recommendation:

6. REMARKS

7a. NAME OF SUBMITTER (Last, First, MI) – Optional	b. WORK TELEPHONE NUMBER (Include Area Code) – Optional
c. MAILING ADDRESS (Street, City, State, ZIP Code) – Optional	8. DATE OF SUBMISSION (YYMMDD)

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